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The Commander

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THE COMMANDER

By Steve DuBois

[Actor 1 plays two characters: MUTEBA, a monstrous commander of child soldiers, and THE COMMANDER, a benevolent invisible guardian whom only Fabrice can hear, and who may or may not be real.]

[Actor 2 plays FABRICE, a 12-year-old child soldier struggling for survival. At times, his demeanor changes from that of a frightened boy to that of a confident adult as the spirit of the Commander occupies him.]

[At various points in the performance, THE COMMANDER addresses the audience directly, serving as a narrator. Fabrice is confined by the fourth wall, though his thoughts become audible at times.]

1 COMMANDER: [*Narrating, from behind Fabrice*] The pieces of Fabrice's weapon were arrayed before him, cleaned and oiled and ready for assembly, glinting under the tropical sun. But he had had nothing but a handful of cassava for supper last night, snd he could not for the life of him remember how to put them back together again.

2 FABRICE: I…I know this. I have done this a dozen times. A hundred times! I must remember!

1 COMMANDER: The years, under Sergeant Muteba's leadership had taught Fabrice and the other boys many things. How to assemble and disassemble a weapon. How to make a meal of grubs and grass. How to raise their rifles on another boy, and see the lights go out in his eyes. And above all, how to forget. And now, sure enough, Fabrice had forgotten.

2 FABRICE: Muteba will beat me, and I am in no shape to take another beating. He will kill me, and there will be no one left to shield the other boys from him. They will put me in the ground, and move on, but there will be no one to protect them from Muteba. Here he comes now, up the line…

1 MUTEBA: [*Hitting a boy*] No, you fool! You must learn to care for your weapon! Your weapon is your life! Do you hear me? Your weapon is your life!

2 FABRICE: My life…here in pieces before me. So hungry. I cannot remember. Maybe…maybe if I…

1 COMMANDER: [*To Fabrice, insistent but not unkind*] No, boy! That is not how it is done!

2 FABRICE: What? Who…who is speaking? I…I hear you, but I cannot see you…

1 COMMANDER: Look at the pieces before you. It is a monumental task, for one so young. Like eating an elephant! Tell me, Fabrice, how does one eat an elephant?

2 FABRICE: Who are you? Where are you? How do you know my name?

1 COMMANDER: One bite at a time. One eats an elephant one bite at a time. Here. Allow me to assist you…

[*The two of them move in perfect unision. Fabrice stares down at his hands, amazed, as they do the work for him, of their own accord.]*

1 COMMANDER: Short end of the bolt into the bolt carrier…so! Rotate counter-clockwise until the click…so!

2 FABRICE: My hands…how…

1 COMMANDER: Carrier group to the gas piston chamber, notches aligned, into the opening… so! Spring in the rear opening, aligning with the opening…

2 FABRICE: [*Remembering, eyes wide*] Muteba…that night in the tent…drunk on lotoko, calling out to me, smiling, his belt…his belt undone…

1 COMMANDER: Not now, Fabrice! One bite at a time. Spring into receiver…so! Rear sight folded forwards…so! Dust cover into place, shut with a snap…so! Yes. Just so.

2 FABRICE: And he is coming. Muteba…

1 MUTEBA: [*To the other boys*] Do not look at me! I will not countenance eye contact! [*To Fabrice*] Yes. Good, Fabrice. You are a good soldier, my boy. [*He caresses Fabrice's cheek. Fabrice shudders as he moves on*]

1 COMMANDER: And what would you know of being a good soldier, Muteba?

2 FABRICE [*Terrified*] Quiet! He will hear you!

1 COMMANDER: He cannot hear me, Fabrice. No one but you can hear me. For it is you I have chosen.

2 FABRICE: Who…who are you? For what have I been chosen?

1 COMMANDER: Who am I? I once had a name, though I scarce remember it. But you and the other boys are soldiers, or so Muteba says. A soldier has no name, but only a rank. Therefore, let us call me The Commander.

[*Intro here*]

[*Fabrice huddles in a foxhole, rifle raised, as the Commander narrates.*]

1 COMMANDER: Another battle. The enemy were boys no older than themselves. The men of the nation were used up long ago.

2 FABRICE: Muteba, behind us, far to the rear, screaming for us to advance. But we who have lasted, we know. The boy who rises to advance will be scythed down instantly. To obey is to die. To flee is to die. Ignore the order, and pretend not to hear, and I may live. For today.

1 COMMANDER: Squeeze the trigger, Fabrice…yes, just so. It will be over soon. Soon, one side will grow tired of the fiasco, and retreat.

2 FABRICE: And then, the night. Muteba, cooking up the lotoko mash, inviting whatever boy fights best to his tent. Best not to fight too well.

1 COMMANDER: Best not to fight at all. [*To Fabrice*] Look, Fabrice! Across the clearing! They are trying to outflank you!

2 FABRICE: What? Where are you…

[*Their heads move in perfect unison. As the Commander raises his arm, Fabrice raises his.]*

1 COMMANDER: There! In the trees! They seek to move towards the bluff on your right!

2 FABRICE: Yes! Yes, I see…

1 COMMANDER: From the bluff, they will be able to enfilade you from above. Your cover will be useless. You will be slaughtered.

2 FABRICE: What can I do? I cannot advance, I cannot retreat, and I cannot stay where I am…

1 COMMANDER: Think, boy! A good soldier relies on his comrades.

[*The Commander and Fabrice speak as one. Fabrice's demeanor and voice are no longer that of a boy—he is calm, powerful, commanding*.]

1 AND 2: Sony! You must cover me, and hold off the enemy! Pierre! You must turn your rifle around, and hold off Muteba! Do you understand! [*Pause*] My brave friends! Good luck to you!

[*Moving as one, The Commander and Fabrice hop up out of the foxhole and burst into a sprint. Fabrice stares down at his legs in shock as they move without his control*.]

1 COMMANDER: Around them, Fabrice. Around the outside. The enemy are intent on your original position. We will out-flank the flankers!

2 FABRICE: How is this possible? Are you a demon, to possess my body so?

1 COMMANDER: No, Fabrice. Though some would say I once was one.

2 FABRICE: Is my soul in danger?

1 COMMANDER: In war, Fabrice, every soldier's soul is in danger! But look, there, ahead, atop the bluff. They are preparing to fire on your comrades!

2 FABRICE: But their backs are to us!

[*They no longer move in unison. Fabrice raises the rifle, his voice full of vengeance*]

2 FABRICE: The first one, the one in camoflauge. Squeeze the trigger…so! The second one, the dark skinned one. Squeeze the trigger…so! The third one, the boy, my own age, his rifle lowered, his eyes wide—Ha! yes, I have got you! Squeeze the trigger…squeeze the…

[*The Commander raises his own hands into firing position, mirroring Fabrice's. Fabrice struggles, but he cannot make his finger move. Slowly, in unison, they lower the rifle*.]

2 FABRICE: He's getting away! Why? They were the enemy! They wanted to kill us! They deserved to die!

1 COMMANDER: Fabrice…the first two deaths were necessary, to save your friends. But they were not deserved. No one in this war, save those who perpetuate it and profit by it, deserves to die. And the third boy…his death was neither deserved nor necessary.

[*Fabrice scowls, a petulant boy, and kicks a rock away.]*

1 COMMANDER: I fear, Fabrice, that you have seen too much death, that you have grown a callus on your soul. Yet I also know that there is mercy in you. Look behind you, Fabrice. Look what has happened.

[*They turn in unison. Fabrice's expression slowly changes from petulance to sorrow*.]

2 FABRICE: Sony! Pierre! My friends! No…no!

1 COMMANDER: They died to save you, Fabrice, and the whole platoon. From your true enemy. Behold, Fabrice. Your true enemy advances.

2 FABRICE: Muteba!

1 MUTEBA: COWARD! TRAITOR! YOU HAVE DENIED ME VICTORY, FABRICE! YOU HAVE DENIED…

[Fabrice says nothing. Eyes downcast, he gestures at the men he has just killed.]

1 MUTEBA: You have denied…you have…oh. Oh! [*A slow, stupid smile spreads over his face*.] Oh! A cunning stratagem! An advance against the enemy, just as I ordered! [*He wags a finger at the other boys*.] Did I not order you to advance? And here, finally, is a soldier who takes orders! I am a commander who will always countenance cunning and bravery!

[*He sweeps Fabrice into a one-armed embrace. Fabrice cringes in terror*.]

1 MUTEBA: A cheer for Fabrice, boys! A CHEER, I SAID! [*To Fabrice*] This calls for a celebration, don't you think? Let's have a drink, back at my tent, you and I, my brave boy…

[*Scene break*]

[*Fabrice sits, eyes downcast. Muteba stands tall, leering, cooking something over a fire.]*

1 MUTEBA: Command is a lonely burden, my boy, and a heavy one. Ah, our drink is ready. [*He lifts a cup from above the fire, and offers it to Fabrice, who shakes his head, his eyes downcast*.] Are you sure? It will make things easier, I promise. *[Fabrice shakes his head again. Muteba shrugs, and takes a long swallow*.] No man who has not picked up the burden of command can know its weight. No man can know the pain I feel at the loss of each soldier under my protection. You may look at me, you know. You have earned the privilege. I will countenance eye contact, under these unique circumstances. [*He places a finger under Fabrice's chin, forces his head up. As soon as he removes his finger, Fabrice's eyes return to the ground*.] As you will. [*Muteba takes another long draw from the cup.]* But it is not the luxury of the commander to allow himself to feel these deaths as keenly as he might. For if the commander succumbs to grief, who will lead his soldiers? To be a commander is to learn to put one's own deepest feelings aside. One must advance.

[*As Muteba speaks, Fabrice's eyes begin to slowly lift from the ground, and to fill with a strange light. His posture moves slowly from stooped to erect. Muteba, lost in his rant, does not notice*.]

1 MUTEBA: Now, you, Fabrice, it seems to me that you have the stuff of command in you.

[*Fabrice speaks under his breath. His voice is not at all that of a boy*.]

2 FABRICE: Yes. Just so.

1 MUTEBA: But you care too deeply, Fabrice. The boys will follow you. You proved that today, with Sony and Pierre. But to allow yourself to care as you do? It is a mistake. To care too much can drive a commander mad.

2 FABRICE: [*Under his breath*] And the commander is mad indeed.

[*Muteba, half-drunk, wraps his arm around Fabrice's shoulders as he speaks. Fabrice's hand moves steadily around Muteba's waist, unfastening the gun holster on his opposite hip.*]

1 MUTEBA: Let me help you, Fabrice. Let me help you go away to a place inside, where you cannot be hurt, where one can do that which needs doing without shame. Let us give you some practice. *[He loosens his belt.]* That is an order, and I will not countenance dissent.

2 FABRICE: *[Fabrice breaks free, and steps back, turning to face Muteba. He raises his eyes. In his hands he holds Muteba's pistol.]* No more than we shall countenance you any longer, Muteba.

1 MUTEBA: What…my…

2 FABRICE: Your weapon. Your weapon is your life.

1 MUTEBA [*Not intimidated.]* Ah, but are you sure, boy? Have you truly learned the lessons I have tried to teach you? Are you ready to be a leader? No. No, I think not. You have always been soft, boy. You have not the hard heart of a true killer!

2 FABRICE [*A frightened boy again*] No. I do not.

[*Muteba disappears behind Fabrice, who stands alone, with the pistol raised.]*

2 FABRICE But I know one who does. [*In voice not his own*] Allow me to assist you. [*He squeezes the trigger twice, then slowly lowers the pistol.]*

[*The Commander reappears.*]

1 COMMANDER: A death that was both deserved and necessary.

2 FABRICE: Just so. And now, at last…who are you?

[A long pause.]

1 COMMANDER: I was a soldier, Fabrice. I led men into battle, and later, to my shame, I led boys. Death came for me, eventually, as is the way of war. And yet I did not die, but live on. It is my fate, Fabrice, to be one with the children of battle. My soul bonds with that of a boy. I share his experiences and his pain. And I must live on in this fashion forever—or until twenty-four hours pass without a single child of this nation firing a weapon in anger. Until then, I can never rest.

2 FABRICE: But…that is impossible. You have been set an impossible task.

1 COMMANDER: How does one eat an elephant, Fabrice?

2 FABRICE: One bite at a time.

1 COMMANDER: Yes. Just so.

2 FABRICE: How can I help?

1 COMMANDER: You may help by becoming a soldier in my army, Fabrice. By guiding your platoon back to safety and then refusing to take up arms again. By telling the story of your life to all who will listen, for in this new war, your life is your weapon. And you may help by telling them about me, Fabrice. Spread the word to every village and camp. Let the boy soldiers know that the Commander is on the prowl, and that I am coming quickly to their aid, to be their partner and their shield. It is your mission, and mine, to teach them their true strength. To show them what it is to be a man and a soldier. To tell them who the true enemies are, and at whom the guns should be pointed. And tell the Mutebas as well! Tell them the Commander is coming for them. I leave you now, my soldier, to your mission. Tell them all, Fabrice, that the Commander is coming.

[*He disappears*]

2 FABRICE: And with that, he was gone. And yet I felt no dimunition of my strength. There was only my purpose. The boys waiting for me, back in camp. And the rest of the boys, everywhere, waiting for my story. What had I to fear? I was a man with a mission, ready to advance, and fully in command.

[*For a moment, the Commander reappears, and places a hand on Fabrice's shoulder.]*

1 COMMANDER: Yes. Just so.